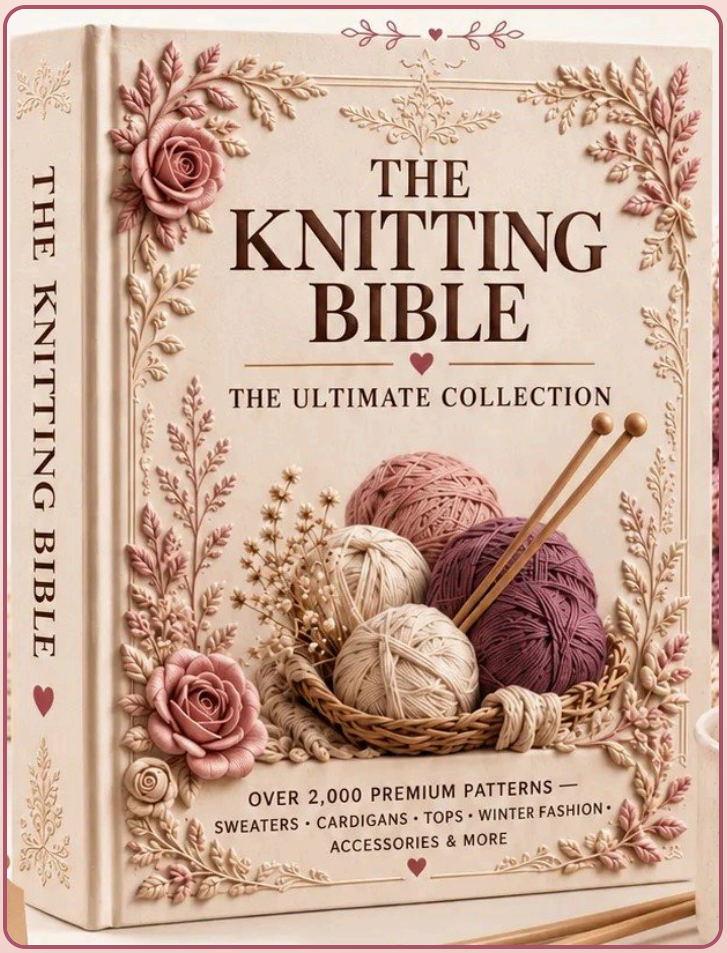
BONUS 3

T-Shirt Yarn Bags

Turn scrap fabric into stylish totes



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Welcome to T-Shirt Yarn Bags

> *Somewhere in your home there is a stack of old T-shirts that nobody wears. This bonus shows you how to turn that stack into sturdy, good-looking tote bags, baskets, pouches and beach bags that you will actually carry. You do not need special equipment: a pair of sharp scissors, a large hook or a pair of big needles, and a few worn-out cotton tees are enough to start.*

In this guide you will learn how to choose shirts, cut one into a single long strand without joins, work out how much yarn a project needs, and make eight complete bags, from a simple crochet market tote to a two-color striped tote. Every pattern lists the materials, the finished size, the stitch and round counts, handle options and finishing steps.

> **How to use this guide**
>
> Read Sections 1 to 3 once, then pick a project. If you are new to T-shirt yarn, start with the pouch or the drawstring bag: they use little yarn, so a mistake costs you an evening, not a weekend. All numbers in the patterns were counted for a swatch gauge you can check yourself before you begin.

1. Why T-Shirt Yarn?

There are three good reasons to cut up old shirts. The first is cost. A bag-sized project needs several shirts, and tees from your closet, a family member or a thrift shop cost very little, often just a dollar or two each. Compare that to the price of the same yardage in a thick specialty yarn and the savings are obvious.

The second reason is strength. Cotton jersey is a knit fabric, so when you stretch a strip the edges roll in and form a round, springy cord. Stitched at a tight gauge, that cord makes a dense fabric that holds a heavy load. Bags made from it carry books, groceries, towels and sandals without sagging.

> **A note on selling**
>
> If you plan to sell what you make, check the rules of the market or craft fair where you sell. Some places ask for labels, fiber content or a specific kind of booth. Always use clean, safe materials.

2. Choosing Your T-Shirts

The best fabric

Look for 100 percent cotton jersey: a soft, thin, single-knit fabric. It curls into a round cord when pulled, cuts easily and washes well. The thinner and softer the shirt, the smoother the yarn. Test one strip: if the edges roll in when you pull it, the shirt is good.

What to avoid

- Heavy, stiff or thick tees: they make bulky cord that is hard to pull through stitches.
- Tees with large rubbery or cracked screen prints: the print does not stretch and can crack or peel. Choose plain shirts or ones with small prints you can cut around.

- Shirts with heavy side seams, thick collars or embroidery in the area you plan to use.
- Very sheer or worn-out fabric with holes or thin patches. It will snap when you stretch it.
- Dirty or musty shirts. Wash and dry everything first.

Size matters

Bigger shirts give more yarn. These are approximate yards for 1 in strips from a tube trimmed of hem, sleeves and shoulders. For your own shirt: (tube height / strip width) x circumference / 36 = yards.

SHIRT SIZE	FLAT WIDTH (IN)	CIRCUMFERENCE (IN)	USABLE TUBE HEIGHT (IN)	APPROX. YARDS AT 1 IN STRIPS
Small	18	36	17	17
Medium	20	40	19	21
Large	22	44	20	24
XL	24	48	21	28
2XL	26	52	22	31

How many shirts for what?

Shirt counts include 10 percent extra for joins and waste, rounded up. All projects assume Large tees at 24 yards each (3/4 in strips: 31 yards).

PROJECT	STRIP WIDTH	APPROX. YARDS	LARGE TEES NEEDED
1. Crochet market tote	1 in	184	9
2. Knit garter tote	1 in	209	10
3. Round bottom basket bag	1 in	119	6
4. Beach bag with mesh	1 in	193	9
5. Small zippered pouch	3/4 in	56	2
6. Crossbody bag	1 in	126	6
7. Drawstring bag	1 in	100	5
8. Striped tote, 2 colors	1 in	209	10 (6 main color, 4 contrast)

3. How to Make Continuous T-Shirt Yarn

One shirt can be cut into a single unbroken strand with no joins. Work on a flat table with a cutting mat under the shirt.

> **Safety first**
>
> You are working with sharp tools. Use fabric shears or a rotary cutter, never dull craft scissors you have to force. Put a self-healing cutting mat under your work, cut away from your body, and keep your free hand behind the ruler, not in front of it. Close the blade guard on a rotary cutter every time you set it down. Keep tools away from children and pets.

Step by step

1. **Prepare the shirt.** Wash and dry it. Lay it flat and smooth out wrinkles.
2. **Cut off the hem.** Cut a straight line just above the bottom hem and remove the stitched band, about 1 in. Hems are thick and do not stretch.
3. **Remove the sleeves and top.** Cut straight across the shirt just under the armpits, level with the bottom edge. Set the sleeves, neck and shoulders aside; you can use the sleeve fabric for small projects. You are left with a tube about 20 in tall and 22 in wide when lying flat (44 in around).
4. **Mark your lines.** With the tube flat, front layer on top of the back layer, measure from the cut bottom edge and mark a line every 1 in all the way up, from 1 in to 19 in. That makes 19 lines and 20 bands, each 1 in tall.
5. **Cut the slits.** Starting at the left folded edge, cut along each line through both layers. Stop exactly 1 in before the right edge. Do not cut the last inch. The shirt now looks like a comb, with 20 flat bands held together by an uncut inch on the right.
6. **Open the tube.** Spread the tube open so the uncut zone faces you. It is a vertical strip about 2 in wide (1 in on the front layer and 1 in on the back layer, joined at the fold).
7. **Cut the spiral.** Start at the bottom band. On the left side of the uncut zone, find the end of the first slit. Cut diagonally from that point up to the end of the second slit on the right side of the zone. Then cut from the left end of the second slit diagonally to the right end of the third slit. Keep going, always one slit higher, until you reach the top band. Each diagonal cut is about 2 in long.
8. **Lift the strand.** Pick up the bottom end. The shirt has become one long band of 1 in cloth, about 24 yards in total.

The cutting diagram in words

Picture a ladder lying on its side. The two long sides of the ladder are the left fold and the right uncut zone. The rungs are the 20 bands, each 1 in tall. Now imagine the ladder wrapped around a cylinder. The rungs are rings. Every diagonal cut in the uncut zone breaks one ring open and joins its end to the start of the ring above, so the rings turn into one long spiral that climbs the cylinder like a staircase. The bottom end of the spiral is where you started and the top end is the top band.

Stretching

Hold the strand a few feet from one end and pull it hard hand over hand, like pulling a rope. The edges roll toward the center and the strip curls into a round cord about half its width. Work all the way along, but do not pull so hard that it breaks.

Joining strips

You will need a join whenever you start a new shirt or break a strand. A slit-and-loop join is quick and almost invisible:

1. Cut a slit about 1/2 in long near the end of strip A, in the middle of the strip.
2. Push the end of strip B through the slit and pull about 3 in through.
3. Cut a slit in the end of strip B, then pass the other end of strip A through the new slit and pull tight.
4. The two ends now lock together. Trim any long tails and tuck them into the next stitches.

Winding balls

4. Yardage and Thickness Guide

The strip width sets how fine or thick the yarn is. Yardage is for a Large tube 20 in tall and 44 in around: bands = 20 / width, yards = bands x 44 / 36, rounded down.

STRIP WIDTH	BANDS FROM ONE TEE	YARDS FROM ONE TEE	CORD WIDTH ONCE STRETCHED	CROCHET HOOK	KNITTING NEEDLES	BEST FOR
1/2 in (1.3 cm)	40	48	about 1/4 in	N/P-15 (10 mm)	10 mm (US 15)	Small pouches, trims
3/4 in (1.9 cm)	26	31	about 3/8 in	N/P-15 (10 mm)	12 mm (US 17)	Pouches, small bags
1 in (2.5 cm)	20	24	about 1/2 in	Q (16 mm)	15 mm (US 19)	Totes, baskets, bags
1 1/2 in (3.8 cm)	13	15	about 3/4 in	S (19 mm)	19 mm (US 35)	Chunky baskets, rugs
2 in (5 cm)	10	12	about 1 in	S (19 mm) or larger	25 mm or larger	Floor baskets, very quick work

Check any row: for 1 in strips, 20 / 1 = 20 bands, 20 x 44 in = 880 in, and 880 / 36 = 24.4, so 24 yards. For 3/4 in strips, 20 / 0.75 = 26 bands (rounded down), 26 x 44 = 1,144 in, and 1,144 / 36 = 31.8, so 31 yards.

Gauge used in this bonus

The patterns below use 1 in strips and a Q (16 mm) hook unless stated, with this gauge:

- **Single crochet:** 5 stitches and 5 rows = 2 in (2.5 stitches and 2.5 rows per inch).
- **Half double crochet:** 5 stitches = 2 in and 4 rounds = 2 in.
- **Garter stitch with 15 mm needles (US 19):** 10 stitches = 4 in and 16 rows = 4 in.
- **The pouch (project 5)** uses 3/4 in strips and an N/P-15 (10 mm) hook: 3 single crochet = 1 in and 3 rows = 1 in.

Always swatch

Work a swatch 12 stitches wide and 12 rows tall and measure it. If you get more stitches in 4 in than the gauge says, use a larger hook. If you get fewer, use a smaller one. T-shirt yarn varies with the shirt and your hands, so change the hook, not the pattern.

Estimating yarn for any project

For this gauge a single crochet uses about 2.5 in of yarn, and a half double crochet or a knit stitch uses about 3 in. To measure your own: crochet 10 stitches, unravel them, and measure the yarn. Divide by 10. Multiply by the stitch count of the pattern, divide by 36 for yards, then add 10 percent. Every estimate in this bonus was calculated that way.

5. Tools and Materials

- **Crochet hook:** a US N/P-15 (10 mm) for thinner strands, Q (16 mm) or larger for 1 in strips. Aluminum or plastic hooks with a smooth head glide best. Wood can grab the fabric.
- **Knitting needles:** 15 mm (US 19) or larger for 1 in strips. Straight or circular both work; straight needles are fine for flat pieces.
- **Sharp fabric scissors:** keep a pair just for cloth.
- **Rotary cutter, ruler and cutting mat (optional):** faster and more even than scissors, especially for many shirts. The blade is very sharp, so use it with care and cover it after every cut.
- **Stitch markers:** to mark the start of each round. A safety pin or a scrap of contrasting cord also works.
- **Large blunt needle:** for sewing seams and weaving in ends, and a regular sewing needle and thread for lining.
- **Measuring tape, fabric marker and clips:** to hold pieces together while you sew.

6. Crochet Stitches You Need

Four stitches and one increase build every crochet project here. Work slightly loose, because tight stitches make stiff fabric. Abbreviations: ch = chain, sc = single crochet, sl st = slip stitch, hdc = half double crochet, st(s) = stitch(es). For a circle start, ch 2 and work 6 sc into the 2nd chain from the hook; a magic ring is hard with thick cord.

Chain (ch)

Make a slip knot, wrap the yarn over the hook and pull it through the loop. That is one chain. Repeat, chaining loosely so the foundation row is as wide as the rows above it.

Slip stitch (sl st)

Insert the hook into a stitch, wrap the yarn and pull through both the stitch and the loop on the hook. It is used to join a round and to make a flat edge.

Single crochet (sc)

Insert the hook into the stitch, wrap the yarn and pull up a loop (two loops on the hook). Wrap the yarn again and pull through both loops. One sc is done. It makes a dense, firm fabric that is ideal for bags.

Half double crochet (hdc)

Wrap the yarn over the hook first, then insert the hook into the stitch. Wrap the yarn and pull up a loop (three loops on the hook). Wrap again and pull through all three loops. It is taller and a little softer than sc.

Increase and back loop only

To increase, work 2 sc in the same stitch. In rounds, mark the first stitch of each round with a marker and work in a spiral (do not join), moving the marker up as you go. To turn a flat base into walls, work one round into the back loop only (blo): insert the hook only into the loop farthest from you. This leaves a clean ridge and makes the corner crisp.

7. The Knitting Option

T-shirt yarn knits up beautifully on large needles, and garter stitch (knit every row) is the best choice. It lies flat, has no curl and gives a thick, reversible fabric. You only need three skills: casting on, the knit stitch and binding off.

- **Cast on (knit cast on):** make a slip knot on the left needle. Insert the right needle into the loop, wrap the yarn, pull through and place the new loop on the left needle. Repeat, always working into the last stitch made. Keep it loose.
- **Knit stitch:** insert the right needle into the front of the first stitch on the left needle, wrap the yarn, pull a loop through and slide the old stitch off.
- **Bind off:** knit 2 stitches, pass the first stitch over the second and off the needle. Knit one more and repeat until one stitch is left. Cut the yarn and pull it through.

8. The Eight Bag Projects

Each pattern gives a finished size, materials, counts you can check, handle options and finishing. Counts are shown in brackets so you can verify each round. If you need to change size, adjust the chain or cast-on by multiples of the stitch repeat and recalculate the round counts. Unless stated otherwise, work in a spiral, without joining or turning chains, and fasten off at the end of each pattern.

Project 1: Simple Crochet Market Tote

The classic starter bag. A flat rectangular base, straight walls and cutout handles worked into the bag itself, so you never sew a strap. It stands up on its own and holds a full load of groceries.

- **Skill level:** Beginner
- **Finished size:** 12 in wide x 4 in deep x about 11.5 in tall (30 cm x 10 cm x 29 cm)
- **Materials:** 1 in T-shirt yarn, about 184 yd (9 Large tees); Q (16 mm) hook; stitch marker; large blunt needle

- **Gauge:** 5 sc and 5 rows = 2 in

Pattern

1. Ch 31. **Row 1:** sc in the 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across (30 sc).
2. **Rows 2 to 10:** ch 1, turn, sc in each of the 30 sts. You now have a base 12 in wide and 4 in long (30 sts, 10 rows).
3. **Round 1:** ch 1 and do not turn. Sc in each of the 30 sts along the top edge, work 10 sc down the short side (one per row end), 30 sc in the unused loops of the starting chain, then 10 sc up the last short side: 30 + 10 + 30 + 10 = 80 sc. Place a marker in the first stitch and work in a spiral.
4. **Rounds 2 to 26:** sc in each of the 80 sc (25 rounds).
5. **Round 27 (handle gaps):** sc in the next 10, skip 10, ch 10, sc in the next 30, skip 10, ch 10, sc in the last 20: 10 + 10 + 30 + 10 + 20 = 80 sts. The two gaps fall in the middle of the two long sides.
6. **Rounds 28 and 29:** sc in each sc and each ch (80 sts). Join with sl st and fasten off. That is 29 rounds in all, about 11.6 in.

Handle options

- **Cutout handles:** as above. Each opening is 10 sts (4 in) wide, and no extra yarn is needed.
- **Sewn straps (extra 50 yd, 11 Large tees in total):** skip round 27 and work plain sc instead. Make 2 straps: ch 6, sc in 2nd ch and each ch across (5 sc), then sc in each stitch for 70 rows (28 in). Sew each end to the inside rim, 10 stitches in from each side.
- **Reinforced handles:** double the strap over a strip of the same cord before you sew it on.

Weave in all ends. Lay the bag flat and press the base into shape with your hands. For a firmer bottom, add a stiff base (see the strengthening tips in Section 9).

Project 2: Knit Garter Tote

A reversible, squishy bag knitted flat in one piece and folded. Garter stitch is thick enough to hold its shape without lining.

- **Skill level:** Beginner knitter
- **Finished size:** 10 in wide x 10 in tall, with 16 in straps
- **Materials:** 1 in T-shirt yarn, about 209 yd (10 Large tees); 15 mm (US 19) needles; large blunt needle
- **Gauge:** 10 sts and 16 rows = 4 in in garter stitch

Pattern

1. Cast on 25 sts loosely (10 in).
2. Knit every row for 80 rows (20 in, 40 ridges). Count the ridges on one side; there should be 40.
3. Bind off loosely knitwise.
4. Fold the piece in half so the cast-on edge meets the bind-off edge. The fold is the bottom of the bag: 20 in divided by 2 is 10 in tall.

5. Sew each side seam (40 rows, 10 in long) with whip stitch, going through the edge stitches only.
6. Cast on 4 sts. Knit every row for 64 rows (16 in). Bind off.
7. Sew the ends inside the top of the bag, 3 in from each side seam, so the two ends of one strap are 4 in apart (10 in - 3 in - 3 in = 4 in).

Handle options

- **Short grab handles:** the straps above.
- **Shoulder straps:** knit them 28 in long (112 rows).
- **Rope handles:** braid three 1 in strips instead of knitting.

Finishing: weave in ends and tug the bag into shape. Knit bags stretch with use, so keep the load moderate and add a base of fabric if you carry heavy items.

Project 3: Round Bottom Basket Bag

A rounded basket worked from the center out. It holds its own shape and makes a pretty storage basket as well as a bag for yarn or craft projects.

- **Skill level:** Confident beginner
- **Finished size:** about 7.5 in across x 9 in tall (19 cm x 23 cm)
- **Materials:** 1 in T-shirt yarn, about 119 yd (6 Large tees); Q (16 mm) hook; stitch marker
- **Gauge:** 5 sc and 5 rounds = 2 in

Pattern

1. **Round 1:** ch 2, 6 sc in the 2nd ch from hook (6 sts).
2. **Round 2:** 2 sc in each st (12 sts).
3. **Round 3:** *sc in the next st, 2 sc in the next*, repeat 6 times (18).
4. **Round 4:** *sc in the next 2, 2 sc in the next*, repeat 6 times (24).
5. **Rounds 5 to 10:** keep adding 6 stitches in each round by working one more plain sc before each increase (30, 36, 42, 48, 54, 60). Round 10 is *sc in the next 8, 2 sc in the next*, repeat 6 times (60). Every round n has 6 x n sts.
6. **Round 11:** sc in the back loop only of each st (60).
7. **Rounds 12 to 30:** sc in each st (19 rounds, 60 sts).
8. **Round 31 (handle gaps):** sc in the next 10, skip 10, ch 10, sc in the next 20, skip 10, ch 10, sc in the last 10: 10 + 10 + 20 + 10 + 10 = 60.
9. **Rounds 32 and 33:** sc in each st and ch (60). Join with sl st and fasten off. The walls are 23 rounds, about 9.2 in.

Handle options

- Built-in cutout handles, as above, with openings 4 in wide.

- Sewn straps from the Project 1 instructions. Skip round 31, and sew the straps 15 sts apart on opposite sides.
- A rolled top: fold the top 3 rounds to the outside and stitch loosely.

Project 4: Beach Bag with Mesh

A roomy open-weave bag that lets sand fall out and wet towels breathe. It uses the same rectangular base as the market tote.

- **Skill level:** Beginner
- **Finished size:** 12 in wide x 4 in deep x 9.2 in tall (30 cm x 10 cm x 23 cm), plus 24 in straps
- **Materials:** 1 in T-shirt yarn, about 193 yd (9 Large tees); Q (16 mm) hook; stitch marker; large blunt needle
- **Gauge:** 5 sc and 5 rows = 2 in

Pattern

1. Make the base exactly as Project 1: ch 31, 30 sc in row 1, then rows 2 to 10 (30 sts, 10 rows).
2. **Round 1:** edge round of 80 sc (30 + 10 + 30 + 10).
3. **Rounds 2 and 3:** sc in each st (80).
4. **Round 4:** *sc in the next st, ch 1, skip 1 st*, repeat 40 times. This uses all 80 sts.
5. **Rounds 5 to 19:** *sc in the next ch-1 space, ch 1*, repeat 40 times. That is 16 mesh rounds in all (rounds 4 to 19), each with 40 sc and 40 ch = 80.
6. **Round 20:** *sc in the next sc, sc in the next ch-1 space*, repeat 40 times (80 sts).
7. **Rounds 21 to 23:** sc in each st (80). Join with sl st and fasten off. Total height is 23 rounds, 9.2 in (3 + 16 + 4).

Handle options

- **Flat straps (make 2):** ch 6, sc in 2nd ch and across (5 sc), then 60 rows of sc (24 in). Sew the ends inside the top band, 10 sts from each side seam.
- **Rope handles:** braid three 1 in strips, 60 in long, tie a knot at each end and sew to the inside.
- **Shoulder strap:** make the strap 36 in long (90 rows).

Finishing: the mesh is open, so keep small items in a pouch. For a beach day, lay a towel inside as a liner. Hand wash and dry in the shade so sand does not stay trapped in the weave.

Project 5: Small Zippered Pouch

A pouch for a phone, makeup or knitting notions. It uses thinner 3/4 in strips and a smaller hook so the fabric is flexible enough for a zipper.

- **Skill level:** Beginner
- **Finished size:** 9 in wide x 6 in tall (23 cm x 15 cm)

- **Materials:** 3/4 in T-shirt yarn, about 56 yd (2 Large tees); N/P-15 (10 mm) hook; 9 in zipper; needle and thread; optional fabric for lining
- **Gauge:** 3 sc and 3 rows = 1 in

Pattern

1. Ch 28. **Row 1:** sc in the 2nd ch from hook and across (27 sc, 9 in).
2. **Rows 2 to 36:** ch 1, turn, sc in each of the 27 sts. The piece is 9 in wide and 12 in long (36 rows divided by 3).
3. Fasten off and weave in the ends.
4. Open the zipper. Pin one side along the row 1 edge (27 sts = 9 in) and sew it with a back stitch, using thread and a sharp needle.
5. Sew the other side of the zipper to the row 36 edge. The piece is now a loop.
6. Flatten the loop so the zipper sits at the top and the fold is at the bottom. It is 6 in tall (12 in divided by 2).
7. Sew both sides closed with whip stitch (6 in each), leaving the zipper open so you can turn it right side out.

Handle option

Make a wrist loop: ch 25 loosely (about 8 in) and join to the zipper pull with a sl st. Leave it off if the pouch will go near small children.

Finishing: line the pouch with cotton fabric cut to 10 in x 13 in, hemmed and whip stitched inside, for stiffness and to keep small items from poking through the stitches.

Project 6: Crossbody Bag

A flap bag worked in one piece, with a long strap you wear across the body. It is simple but looks polished.

- **Skill level:** Intermediate beginner
- **Finished size:** 10 in wide x 8 in tall with a 4.8 in flap; strap 48 in
- **Materials:** 1 in T-shirt yarn, about 126 yd (6 Large tees); Q (16 mm) hook; one large snap or 1 1/2 in button; large blunt needle
- **Gauge:** 5 sc and 5 rows = 2 in

Pattern

1. Ch 26. **Row 1:** sc in the 2nd ch from hook and across (25 sc, 10 in).
2. **Rows 2 to 52:** ch 1, turn, sc in each of the 25 sts (52 rows, 20.8 in).
3. The first 20 rows are the front (8 in), rows 21 to 40 are the back (8 in), and rows 41 to 52 are the flap (12 rows, 4.8 in).
4. Fold the piece at the line between row 20 and row 21, so row 1 is the top of the front. Sew the sides with whip stitch (8 in each). The flap folds forward over the front.
5. Ch 5. Sc in the 2nd ch from hook and across (4 sc). Work 120 rows of sc (48 in).
6. Sew the ends to the inside of the side seams, 2 in below the top of the back.

Closure options

- A large snap sewn under the flap and on the front.
- A button on the front and a ch-8 loop in the middle of the flap edge.
- A knotted T-shirt cord that wraps twice around a button.

Finishing: a fabric lining makes this bag far better. Add a small pocket inside for keys. For safety, keep the strap short for children, so it cannot catch or wrap.

Project 7: Drawstring Bag

A round-bottomed stuff sack for shoes, toys or laundry, worked in the round with eyelets for a braided cord.

- **Skill level:** Confident beginner
- **Finished size:** about 6 in across x 9.6 in tall (15 cm x 24 cm)
- **Materials:** 1 in T-shirt yarn, about 100 yd (5 Large tees); Q (16 mm) hook; stitch marker; 3 extra 54 in strips for the cord
- **Gauge:** 5 sc and 5 rounds = 2 in

Pattern

1. **Round 1:** ch 2, 6 sc in the 2nd ch from hook (6).
2. **Rounds 2 to 8:** increase as in Project 3, six stitches each round: 12, 18, 24, 30, 36, 42, 48. Round 8 is *sc in the next 6, 2 sc in the next*, repeat 6 times (48).
3. **Round 9:** sc in the back loop only of each st (48).
4. **Rounds 10 to 28:** sc in each st (19 rounds, 48 sts).
5. **Round 29 (eyelets):** *sc in the next 4, ch 2, skip 2*, repeat 8 times (8 x 6 = 48 sts).
6. **Round 30:** *sc in the next 4, 2 sc in the ch-2 space*, repeat 8 times (48).
7. **Rounds 31 and 32:** sc in each st (48). Join with sl st and fasten off. Walls are 24 rounds, 9.6 in.
8. Braid three 1 in strips, each 54 in long, tightly and evenly. Braiding shortens them to about 46 in.
9. Knot each end and thread the cord in and out of the 8 eyelets. Tie the ends together in a loop.

Handle options

- Use the cord as a backpack strap by threading it through the eyelets from opposite sides.
- Add a bead or toggle only for adult bags.

> **Child safety**
>
> Drawstring cords are a strangulation risk for babies and small children. Do not use a long cord on a bag for a young child, and never leave the bag where a child or pet can chew or tangle in it. Use a short loop or a snap closure instead.

Finishing: weave in ends. Wash the bag before you give it as a gift, and make the cord by hand so it fits your hand comfortably.

Project 8: Striped Tote in Two Colors

A bright striped version of the market tote. It uses half double crochet for walls, which is quicker and a little softer, with a firm sc base.

- **Skill level:** Intermediate beginner
- **Finished size:** 12 in wide x 4 in deep x about 10.5 in tall
- **Materials:** 1 in T-shirt yarn: color A about 124 yd (6 Large tees), color B about 84 yd (4 Large tees); Q (16 mm) hook; stitch marker
- **Gauge:** 5 sc and 5 rows = 2 in; 5 hdc and 4 rounds = 2 in

Pattern

1. Ch 31. **Row 1:** sc in the 2nd ch from hook and across (30 sc). Rows 2 to 10: ch 1, turn, sc in each st (30).
2. **Round 1:** edge round of 80 sc (30 + 10 + 30 + 10), as in Project 1. Place a marker.
3. **Rounds 2 to 5, color B:** hdc in each of the 80 sts (no turning chain, work in a spiral). Change color on the last yarn-over of round 1, carry no yarn, and cut the unused color.
4. **Rounds 6 to 9, color A:** hdc in each st (80).
5. **Rounds 10 to 13, color B:** hdc in each st (80).
6. **Rounds 14 to 17, color A:** hdc in each st (80).
7. **Rounds 18 to 21, color B:** hdc in each st (80). The stripes are 5 x 4 = 20 rounds of hdc, about 10 in.
8. **Round 22, color B:** sl st in each of the 80 sts for a firm edge. Fasten off.

Color B is used for 12 hdc rounds and the slip stitch round, and color A for the base, edge round, 8 hdc rounds and the straps. Keep the colors tidy by changing at the same spot on every stripe, so the join sits at one side seam.

Pattern

1. Ch 6, sc in the 2nd ch from hook and across (5 sc). Work 60 rows of sc (24 in).
2. Sew the ends to the inside, 10 sts in from each side seam.

Handle options

- Contrast straps in color B for a bolder look.
- Double straps: sew two straps together for a stronger handle.
- Short handles: 40 rows (16 in).

Finishing: weave in ends along the stripe edges and press the bag with your hands. If a stripe edge looks bumpy, tug it gently to even it out.

9. Lining and Strengthening

T-shirt yarn bags are sturdy, but two simple extras make them last far longer. A lining stops small items from poking through, and a stiff base keeps the bottom flat when a bag is full.

Adding a lining

1. Choose a tightly woven cotton fabric and wash it first.
2. Measure the bag: circumference, height and base. For the market tote, the walls measure 32 in around (80 sts divided by 2.5) and 11.6 in tall.
3. Cut a rectangle for the walls 1 in bigger each way (33 in x 12.6 in), and a rectangle for the base 13 in x 5 in. That adds a half-inch seam allowance on every side.
4. Sew the short ends of the wall piece together, pin the base to the bottom and sew it on, then press.
5. Slide the lining into the bag wrong side out, fold the top edge in by 1/2 in and hand stitch it just under the rim with small stitches.

A stiff base

- Cut a piece of firm plastic sheeting, plastic canvas or thick cardboard 1/2 in smaller than the base on each side (11 in x 3 in for the market tote).
- Cover it with fabric or slide it between the lining and the bag. Avoid plain cardboard in bags that will get wet.
- Round the corners so they do not poke through.

Reinforced handles

- Sew strap ends over a 2 in overlap and stitch an X inside a box for strength.
- Place a small square of fabric inside the bag under each strap end and sew through all layers.
- For heavy loads, double the strap or run a strip of twill tape along it.

10. Washing and Care

- **Before you start:** wash and dry every shirt to remove sizing and shrink the fabric.
- **Washing a finished bag:** use cold water, a gentle cycle and a mesh laundry bag or pillowcase. Hand wash if the bag has a zipper or lining.
- **Drying:** lay flat, reshape by hand and let it dry out of direct sun. Avoid high heat.
- **Colors:** wash dark and bright bags separately for the first two washes, since new dye can run.
- **Do not iron.** The cord will flatten.
- **Storage:** keep bags stuffed with tissue or a towel to hold their shape.

11. Troubleshooting

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	WHAT TO DO
The strip breaks when I stretch it	Thin or worn fabric, or pulling too hard	Pull gently, use a stronger shirt and cut past any weak patch
The edges do not curl	Polyester blend or a tight knit	Test a strip first; choose a softer cotton jersey
Strips are uneven in width	Marking was off or cuts wandered	Use a ruler and a rotary cutter and cut every 1 in
The bag is floppy and sags	Hook too large, stitches too loose	Go down a hook size, add a base and a lining
The fabric is too stiff	Stitches too tight	Go up a hook size and relax your tension
The base ruffles or cups	Too many or too few increases	Re-count each round (6 stitches times the round number)
Walls flare outward	Extra stitches in the first wall round	Check that you worked 60 or 80 stitches and no more
Joins show	Knots on the outside	Use the slit-and-loop join and hide it on the inside
Colors bleed	New dye in the shirts	Wash dark shirts separately before cutting
Hands hurt	Gripping the hook too hard	Rest often, use an ergonomic hook and loosen your hold

Next Step

Pick one shirt from the bottom of the pile and cut it into one long strand today. Stretch it, wind it into a ball and make the small zippered pouch or the drawstring bag. When you can look at the finished piece and say, *I made that from an old shirt*, you are ready for the larger totes.

YOUR STARTER CHECKLIST

- ☐ Wash and dry 3 to 5 cotton tees
- ☐ Sharp scissors or a rotary cutter and a mat
- ☐ A Q (16 mm) hook and an N/P-15 (10 mm) hook
- ☐ Cut and stretch one shirt into continuous yarn
- ☐ Work a swatch and check your gauge
- ☐ Pick your first project and set out the yarn needed